Today I lost 30 million British Pounds. It was the first time I really made a mistake like this, and it was the first time I thought of the weight of the blow. It vanished and I have nothing to account for it. I was told by my subordinates that it was ok that I lost that money, and it was 'only a drop in the ocean', as our investment and trading company has an evaluation of $30 billion British Pounds. I try to rationalize the loss in my head 'it's only 0.1%' of our estimated value. It weighed on me, throughout the day, even after the market had closed, even at my Omekase lunch.

As I walk out on Canary Wharf, I'm surrounded by the strength and power these financial markets hold. I assure myself everything will be in the exact same spot tomorrow. I travel back to my house in the humble city of Islington. As I roll out of the city in my car, I find myself calm down as the rush hour of the city blends into the quiet suburbia I love. I go home to my wife, and as I walk in, she is startled by my entry while cooking dinner. I assure her that it is just me, and even after 17 years of marriage it seems that she is still not used to the routine that we live everyday. I ask where Tom is, to where she reminds me that he has Rugby training, as he does every Thursday. She asked me about my day, I turned to answer her, but she is more focused on the meal that she is cooking. I wanted to tell her about the mistake, and I forcefully yanked at the knot of my tie to loosen it. Swaying it to find the exact side that gives leverage. After a sigh, I explained to her in layman's terms what happened

today. Even with that she doesn't seem to understand the potential severity of the mistake. I progressed to talk about how things could be affected by the blunder: loss of capital for the company and market instability. Still has a blank expression, her eyes simply staying into place, it was like she was holding back any emotion that can come from her resting face. So I talked about more things that she could relate to; 'I could lose my job', 'We could lose our savings', 'No more trips to Europe' , 'No more Waitrose' then something came out of me. 'No more house', 'no more clothes', 'no more food', ' we will starve and die'. As I was saying this, it reminds me of the dwellers among buildings in Canary Wharf before they are ushered away by security. I pictured myself there for a few seconds, dirty, unhoused, begging for change, I got nauseated by the sight. Then, I decided I never want to allow the chance to lose ever again.

I woke up the next day with a Second Wind, eager to mend my mistake and go beyond, increasing the chance of more earnings for the clients that decided to have their funds managed by us. I did everything right this morning, as I normally do, kiss my wife goodbye, and take the car into the city. I'm thinking of getting a driver. Being at the helm of this coup on London's roads makes me stressed and takes away my focus that I need for work. As I park my car underneath my office, I take a deep sigh, and peel out of the car. Straight focus, going past the security gate, seamlessly tapping my pass, with the right walking speed to get past the

opening doors without stopping. As people come and go out of the elevator and I reach the top, I come out with the same fire I felt yesterday night. It seems like everyone in the office forgot what happened yesterday, but I feel a pit in my stomach sink deeper and deeper as soon as I turn on the work computer and boot up our trading software.

I truly believe the journey that I'm investing in will prevail, its the people's aversion to risk that is making the whole thing fall apart. The protest against the data center in the green belt, is nothing but a small manufactured dip that will repair itself. The government will allow the center to be built, and the AI company will pull in more capital than ever. I need to change the people's mind, and push for this. Being high up as I am, I have access to more of the company's funds than most people do. I really shouldn't do this, because of the 'ethical' implications, but I use our subsidiaries and ghost accounts to pay for the shares that are bought, creating a much needed push for demand to get the ball rolling. As soon as it gets momentum, I will sell the shares to eager buyers, and it was like I was never in places I shouldn't be. For the greater good, and the much deserved return on this high growth stock, it's something I'm willing to justify. Before the markets open, I set up the accounts, and make sure that the credentials are random enough, not to trace it back to me. I close my office door, and shut the blinds. I need full focus for this endeavor if it will pull through. I start off conservatively, following the initial climb

that most companies start with as the market opens. Then I start ramping up the buying, seeing the logs of transactions, to my astonishment, I can't recognize the addresses they come from, it must be others buying into the stock. Through pure adrenaline from my elation, I reach my quota of buying, and I'm at a level to sell where the momentum will stay and I will make my $30 million back, perhaps more even, double that. If I try my luck, triple that. I sink back into my chair with force, it's like I let out all the tension in my body from the last hour. And wonder, how far can I take this?

I start the next morning a little differently, I ride on the high of yesterday, and bask in the fact that not only I came back from my mistake, I made an opportunity from it. I took my morning slow, having a longer shower, and giving my wife a loving kiss as I made my way to the kitchen counter. I ask for her to put on the news, and my face lifts with joy as the financial portion is reporting on my stock, and advises all the punters to get in it as markets open. With my new found silent fame, I decide to take the tube, the excitement will distract me driving. And I want to know what it's like to be among people that don't know that I have manufactured this great wealth increase. Using my credit card, as my oyster card has been expired for years, I squeezed through the gate that violently opens and shuts in milliseconds. I get a little confused by the train station, but I don't worry, I'm just out of practice. As I push everyone on the platform out of the

way as the train pulls up, and with that same violent motion opens its doors, I rush to get a seat before anyone else, I even squeeze through the people that want to come off the train before others board. As I sit down, and grin at everyone around me, I want to share this feeling I have in me with everyone, and try to make their stale, sad faces beam. As the train goes between stops with its deafening whistle, I find the noise to create some solace, adding peace to the happiness. I feel better than ever and I will go into my office, and do it all again.

Almost repeating the exact same thing as I did yesterday, I bought more of the stock. It did make me anxious as I'm pouring more money into this, but I think I was confusing that with something else. Closing the market again with an all time high, I suppressed what I felt and rode the wave for a couple more days.

I follow my new found routine, and I daydream on the tube that after this close I will retire. Although I'm in my 40s, this will propel me into unseen fortune, and I can leave this mistake in the past for the rest of my life. Maneuvering through the station's gates, I almost didn't notice the newspaper strapped to the kiosk before the escalators. Grabbing my full attention as I brisk past it, I abruptly stopped, and the sole of my shoes left a mark. The cheeky tabloid title really got me 'Green Belt's Data Center Plan a Flop'. I rip the newspaper from the cords that held it back,

the clerk yells ‘3 pounds’ for that one. I look at him in bewilderment, does he know I deserve this paper for free, seeing how much this will cost me. I threw a $5 note at him after hastily opening my wallet to fish for it, all the while he stares at me. I scoff and pace down the escalators. I don’t even bother going back to my house to get my car, reading this deserves all my attention. I open the page where their full article is, while trodding down 3 levels of escalators. Following muscle memory, as my head is deep in the paper and I march onto the tube. I open every window near me in the tube, to let air in, even though it’s 5 degrees outside I was burning up. Initially I calmed myself down, the data center was not approved in the city of London, I thought, they will just go somewhere else. Only when my eyes scurry down, I see the deeper shit this company is in. Unreported earnings, suspected government bailout, securities fraud... I could cry at this minute. I swear everyone in the tube will feel the glow of my face as it burns red.

I swear the driver drove the tube slower today. I just made it to the office before the market opened, I sped past everyone in my path, I would’ve pushed people out of my way if I needed to. I didn’t look at my watch, but I knew when I got to my office it was a couple minutes since the market opened. I didn;t have my computer logged out from yesterday, so I immediately dialed in. I had the entire train ride to prepare for the horror but nothing can prepare you for what you see. The red figures contrast more against the

black background, and there is a slight burn into your retinas. I audibly gasped, and hover my hand over my mouth, either out of shock or to stop the vomit coming from my mouth. I tried to sell the stock to recoup any profit, but it was at a heavily discounted price. Admitting the loss hurt my soul, $540 million vanishes after all is done. I don't know how it got this far, but it did, and it rocked me to the core. I heard a tap on my office's wall, it was all window, and it shook through all the panels.

I needed anything to let this burden go, even if it was human interaction. I said come in, and the light that came from the door opening, opposing the black out blinds that were drawn, burned more than the red. It was Will. Will has been my mate for about as long as I can remember, we started in the financial sector, although we were at different companies from time to time, we always manage to come back to each other. He firstly asked if I'm alright, it was earnest and it was what I needed to get me speaking. I said I was, I was just flat out with a project. He brought up the AI Stock's performance this morning.

"I know you were wanting to provide the return we wanted, but sometimes, things don't always work out".

"I'm lucky I abandoned that project a while ago, and I'm working on something else". I replied, lying through my clamped teeth.

Will had a visible pull back in the neck as he heard, and then smiled.

“Then lets get you out of this room”

He walks towards me, to get to the control of the blind. And I quickly pressed the command to sleep on my computer. All the while, opening the curtains, flooding London’s overcast grey into the room.

“A lot of work is going on for a black screen” He chuckled, I chuckled with him. Bringing myself together to get up from my chair and leave the office with him. As far as I know, no one knew it was me, because I was extra careful with masking our dummy accounts. But the company just lost $540 million pounds...

I was on autopilot for the rest of the day, I got home and I don’t remember what I did before I went to bed. But I woke up, in a drunken haze and the hangover never came. I couldn’t bring myself to drive, so I took the tube again. It was like I shared the misery of everyone in the network. I felt like that $540 million was my own, and I’m roaming around in debt, just like everyone else around me. Heading to the office, I don’t go in to my office, I work in the ‘hot desk’ open setting, where most of the company works. I sat down at the few remaining desks, it was certainly a sight.

Most people were looking at me, but I didn't care. No one knows the cloud that hangs over my head, the price being $540 million to be exact.

There is still hunger in me, amongst this cloud. I log into the software to make more purchases, I know I can come back. But everything I did I was seeing red. Losses after loss, until lunch time. Instead of going out, I went down to the cafeteria, at the ground floor of our building, and ate a very sad wrap. Every bite I contemplate my choices, and grow angry in my situation. I can't do much since the market is about to close. But I make my last purchases until it does. I try to play it safe, but as soon as I log in the next day, the whole portfolio is in the red, and for that matter all of the market. Am I doing this? It can't be. I throw whatever I can, more money, more diversification, nothing. It was only until I received a Teams notification for a meeting at 5pm, it was marked as high priority, and the invitees were everyone that traded. The meeting had the title, 'Recent Activity', my heart sank, they didn't shy away from its possibility and I thought of a million scenarios in my head. But, I continued with my work, more money lost until the market closed. I stayed at my desk from 4:30 to around 4:57 to get to the meeting room a little bit later, to save the awkward initial gathering of people.

By the time I got there most of the seats were taken, they were set up in a normal row fashion, but gave the feeling

that the meeting will be extremely formal. So I decided to stand at the back. I've caught a couple of glares from people, as I've been a bit of a recluse in the past few days. I shook hands with a few of the people at my level, and as the Finance general manager walked in from the door that was a couple of centimeters to the right of me, he quickly stopped to shake my hand, and pat my back, and exchanged names as hello, "Jack" I respond to him after saying mine. I'm glad I still can follow our greeting cue and his presence made me calm. He walked to the lectern, and without a moment to gather his thoughts, he started.

"It has come to the financial team's attention that there has been a significant deficit in assets. I'm going to be completely transparent, we don't know the nature of this situation just yet, but we will be taking extreme measures to mitigate any more losses. We will limit transactions for associates traders and traders roles for a couple of months, while we audit our history and get to the bottom of this. I want everyone to report to their line manager going forward where purchases, as they have been briefed on how operations will now run."

After he ended, I was expecting more, but, he always has been very matter of fact, and no filler. There were a few questions, and it seemed that all senior roles will not be affected by this encumbrance. I left the office after that meeting, forgetting my bag at the desk.

When I started the next morning, I was freely trading. I tested if I was subjected to any restrictions by the change, but I was going about my day like nothing has happened, when you start losing money. It seems like the amount doesn't even matter until you start making it back.

I really don't know how long I was trading for until the collapse of the company. I was sitting at my desk, until the Finance's General Manager entered the floor, we made contact for a bit as he strode to the back of the room. Until I hear at the back of me, a deep voice with subtle cracks. He has either been crying or about to cry. I swivel my chair to face him, and it was the first time he earnestly spoke, all his walls were down. All his sentences ended with softness, a contrast to his abruptness. I couldn't make what I felt in the moment, but being confronted with that change moved me. He summarised that the firm will be filing for bankruptcy, and will not be receiving a government bail out. It was jarring, an almost 100 year old company closing its doors after an episode like this. It made me see how much our assets are not tangible, or tied up with something else. With a loss of a billion dollars, it was enough to make it topple like a house of cards. As the final days came and went, more and more people left the office. Only a ghost town remains, where a few stragglers were there to witness the closing of the doors. It was like everyone just got a little bit poorer that day.

The following days after, I saw more homeless people on Canary Wharf. For a moment I thought it was my doing. But, that can't be right? The clients who had their funds managed by us were well off. If they have a few tens of thousands lost by our closure, they will still be on their feet. Seeing the increased number of people, I swear they were rubbing their misfortune in my face. Like the entirety of their life's problems were because of me. As I wander the streets more, looking for other firms to work at, I think about what my future holds. I want to continue on this path, but I need some sort of difference. I assess my options mindlessly walking through the streets.

I don't go outside my house much anymore, with the growth of political instability, most people have taken to the streets. It seems like Ingliston hasn't been hit with them just yet, and I've given a strict curfew for my son to come home straight after school. Britain has lost its mind, and the rest of the world has too. Wealth vanished into thin air, what could have they possibly done to get themselves here, everyone has an issue of not understanding leveraging their wealth and look where they are now. Taking to the streets like it's my problem you can't afford food. The whole world has truly gone mad.

With this all in mind, this has really limited my possibilities in markets to trade in. Trying to find alternatives, there is

one that has had steady growth for as long as I can remember, the weapons manufacturing stocks seem promising to make the fortune I need to get out of here. I feel some insurgence rising in Ingliston, on my walk I see more people boarding up their houses, talks of joining protests and calling out our government on how London is shaping up to be. I have no choice but to leave this country. It's hard to turn my back, but I need to put myself and family first for once, until England stabilizes itself, God save the queen.

Coming to the conclusion of working for myself, I know my rapport is strong enough to have credibility on my own, and I have an excuse to leave London.

At first I tried most European countries, I felt that their drive for innovation was attractive to people who are willing to shovel bucket loads of cash for these ventures, especially the research and development.But I started to realise, the European Union didn't have the hunger for brute force. Places and companies that are dirty and bank on the primitive destruction that comes from war, tend to have more steady gains. I wouldn't describe it as guerilla, and most combat is now done with drones, but the contempt that advancements of weapons can be traded off to sheer accessibility in volumes for them.

I sort after the best, often going to places that are still stable

but have a form of conflict, trying Cambodia and Thailand. I put my son and wife in the best resort in Phuket, while I go to borders and talk with business men, and how to leverage what they are going through to my benefit. There is no other way to put this, I put the bottom line first, and turn up the charm to care about the outcome of these conflicts. I met an ex-colleague from the firm that moved to Bangkok for business. I went with the plan of trying to navigate Thailand's trading sector, and get in with the crowd that I needed. But he now focuses on real estate, developing villas and houses for ex-pats. We caught up for a drink, in a high rise hotel, dimly lit bar, you've seen it before everywhere. We sit on extensively large arm chairs, while a short round table holding our drinks sits just below my knees. As I face him.

We talked about his work now, but mainly focused on our time at the firm. Reminiscing the memories we had. Ignoring actual work related topics, rather focusing on Christmas parties and social events. Then I'm reminded of the man I sat opposite from, who was a bit of a loose cannon. He would drink too much and be unfaithful, and would just take it too far. Although we are not in the same settings of these work events, we didn't shy away from bringing up details in our conversation. I see the same behaviour right now. On the table we were served peanuts with our drinks, he grabbed a small handful, and shoved the peanuts in his mouth. Moving his palm, so they all find a

way into his mouth, taking a snort so he doesn't suffocate. He was a pig and seeing him makes me sick. It was so grotesque, I was steering the conversation to end, so I could leave. Until he fits in a memory about Jack. Something in my brain activated and out of everyone we talked about I was mostly interested in him. I asked what Jack is doing now. He didn't have an answer for me, and quite frankly didn't know what he was doing. I pressed on the matter, I don't know why I had such an urge to know, but I did, and to appease my insistence he simply said

"I believe he moved to China for work, but I think he dropped off the face of the Earth".

I immediately abandoned any prospects in this country. I have my eye set on China, China is leading in nuclear weapons and artillery is just getting larger and larger. It's almost impossible to find an in as the government still has their hand fully in the pie. But, I had a feeling that Jack's influence would help me set up relationships to help me get in. My thoughts are interrupted by him speaking about other topics. I was sick of the man in front of me and his piggish ways. I made some sorry excuse and left almost immediately, he didn't show too much protest in my exit. After I said good bye, and made my way back to the resort I booked a flight to Shanghai, China.

It was hard to get hold of Jack, as his UK number doesn't

work. And his linkedIn hasn't been active for months, so I tried a few people at our firm. Some people didn't know how to contact him, and I had a number but was reluctant to give it to me. It was strange to get this push back, like they didn't know how close we were when we were at the firm. After some persuasion I managed to snag it off someone. I was a bit skeptical with the Chinese area code as the number, but to my surprise putting it in WhatsApp, it worked. I sent him a brief message, about catching up. He didn't respond in the first couple of hours, I didn't mind, but as the day rolled over I was pressed for time as I was going to leave Thailand soon. Until the next day he replied, with just an address. Initially I felt off by the text, but he must be busy, and only had time to send that.

Reading the address, I was initially confused. It wasn't a main city in China, well, not one that I knew of. I put the address in Maps and it came up with the train ride I needed to take out of Shanghai. It was long. But I assume that he is now working at home, or taking a break from work for a bit. I had a lot of things in my mind regarding this whole situation, but I know once I find him I will have a stellar reference and I would be able to seal a deal with an arms dealer.

As I left Thailand to go to China, I landed in Shanghai and I bypass checking in the hotel, and take my carry on with me to see Jack. I navigate to find the right train, and as I sit

down I start to calm down from the rush of the amount of people and the chaos of how China runs.

As the train kept on breezing past stations, more and more people were going off. I start to worry, and wonder if I've missed my stop. But after checking the address for the 3rd time, my little blue circle has ways to go until I reach Jack's stop. As the cityscape now turned into a rural country town, I'm taken back by the change of scenery. It's hard to picture Jack living here, as I recall him living near Canary wharf to be as close as he can to work. Settling in a penthouse apartment that could see most of London. Just as I'm bringing myself back in this time, my mind hears a name of a station called out like the one I need to stop at, and as I look at my phone my dot has moved to the station. I quickly rush to get my bag and my suit jacket, and heave myself off the steps of the train. Catching some air before I hit the ground, I look around. The train station is merely a platform with an information center. I scoff in disbelief, I could not imagine Jack living here, the train stopped at the station looks like a behemoth compared to my surroundings. To tell you the truth I was actually a bit nervous, being in this part of the world. My surroundings were unfamiliar, I haven't been in an environment that devoid of advancement for a very long time.

Looking at my phone, I see that Jack's house is not far from the station so I start walking. My suitcase trailing behind me

loudly on the uneven pavement. I see old people and young people who are dirty. Wheeling produce, keeping their heads down I struggle to meet their eyes. Others are selling food, their language is angry in their bartering and I grow more uneasy as my presence is a stark contrast. After a while the deafening sound of the suitcase turns into another, I realise I'm now walking on gravel. My shoes and suitcase wheels are picking up the rocks, and I start to get dirty. As I persevered, I grew frustrated, looking frantically at the shacks among me, looking for a mansion that I knew jack would live in.

As I pass on, I accidently pass Jack, and I'm stopped by him calling out my name. I stopped in my stride and turned around, he was standing in front of a hut. It was more built up than the other shacks around it, but I'm still paralysed by shock as I turn around. Jack has a beaming smile, and jogs towards me. I'm standing stiff as a board, and if I had fur it would be sticking up. He puts his hand on my shoulder, making me jump even more, as I register his hand on my shoulder, I quickly turn to his other hand out for a handshake. I instinctively shake his hand, and I notice how dirty they are. Almost stained, a filth that can never be washed. As I look up from the shake, I see his face, the same film of dirt covers his face, and he's darker in his skin tone, and more full in the face. He now has his head shaven, about a 2 in buzz length. I can still see Jack from London, and seeing the same smile lets me relax my shoulders and smile

back. We exchange formalities, and I'm more friendly in my tone, more informal, almost excited to talk to him out of pure wonder.

He turns around and leads me into his dwelling, he starts asking questions about my trip, and as he starts to speak longer sentences, I notice his voice has changed, his english accent has faded. I answer him truthfully about what I'm doing now in terms of my work, as I look at his house. Scan almost every inch, and take in what I'm seeing. Clay flooring, tiled bench tops and hand carved wooden furniture. The layout was one big room as the kitchen, well a place to cook, as the wood powered stove is almost dug into the floor, next to a sitting area, with a bed, along with a bathroom that was tucked away by walls. But peaking, it was merely a drop toilet with a bucket for showering.

I'm ducking my head around to get it all, until Jack is in my face again. I put my focus on him now, and take a second look at him. I still can't believe it, his image has completely changed, and when he speaks I know it's him but a changed man. Our small talk has pretty much stayed on the topic of my work. I joking bring up,

"It must be hard to travel to work this far away. Or are you working remotely?"

"I'm not working," he replied with a laugh.

“What” I say with shock but mostly concern.

“Yes, after taking a severance package from our firm, I haven’t worked since” He followed up.

My face must not be hiding my emotions well, as he changes his smile to an earnest one. After a while he says “Wait here, I will get us some stools to sit on, and we can have a catch up”

He picks up at that jogging pace, and picks up 2 cheap plastic squatting stools. He places one next to me, and the other in front of it. He gestures with his hand to sit down, and I reluctantly do so, hiking my suit pants as I do. While he gracefully sits in his. I didn’t see Jack as the man that sat before me, in traditional Chinese clothing. He sat as the man on the top floor of our building in London, with his signature 3 piece suit that he would always wear. I opened my mouth to speak, but before I could say anything. He raises his hand,

I was commanded to silence, and I sat there.

‘I have a feeling you won’t be here for a while, so I will say this now.

When our company went under, it was the first time in 30

years I was without a job. I saw myself in anguish and so much pain. I was lost, and I believe that my salvation will be found by looking for another job. Now that I had so much time on my hands, I became aware of how empty it was. I had no family in my time in London, so I went home to an empty penthouse apartment. And sit and wallow in darkness. I'm usually resilient, and I thought I had the strength to find another job. But I was simply unemployable, I could attribute this to many factors. As I tried to rationalise it more, I started to spiral and consider how much was out of my control. Slipping into a depression I've never felt before, I did things that I never did before. I would walk all over London for hours, days on end. One day I was stopped by Chinese tourists, they started to speak to me in Mandarin, and although I get this a lot, after I said I don't speak Mandarin, something in me switched. It's hard to say what the feeling was, as I felt my chest tighten, it was like I was yearning for something that was missing from my life.

I started to learn Mandarin, taking classes with all the spare time I had. And I changed my life to be submerged by it, watching TV shows, movies and listening to music. I grasped it easily, it was like it was always in me and I just needed help finding it. Learning Mandarin made me think about my parents mostly. I haven't thought about them much after their death. When I look back at memories where they spoke to me or between each other in Mandarin, I felt like I could speak to them again with the language I now have. I

felt warmth for the first time in a while, I started to go out more, but with purpose. I would meet up with other students that took the classes, and we would talk about the future. Most of the people who were learning Mandarin were to help with their job, and they were encouraging me to come to China with them when they go. As I thought of the idea more it seemed more viable and right.

Being born in London, I felt scared to go to China. I have no birth roots in China, only the memories that my parents have from when they lived there, in this exact house. But it was calling me and I couldn't ignore it. I booked a trip to Shanghai, and in the time leading up I sold most of my belongings, my apartment too. I was worried that If I didn't like China, I had nothing to go back to, but what was left for me in London? I just knew I would go to another place and start the process all over again. In the cleaning out of my place, I made sure to keep a box of my family's mementos. Documents, birth certificates and photos. I looked at my parent's expired chinese passport, and found the address that they moved from. I would stay there until I can settle in Shanghai after finding a job.

Coming to China, I was knocked right off my feet. I felt disorientated, and the Mandarin I learnt was miles away to the standard to get around with. But, I managed to make my way to this village. As I arrived at this house, It was left dormant for the time since my parents left, it aged. I asked

the neighbour about the house in the mandarin that I knew, and explained that I was the son of the people who lived in it before. He explained that no one has lived in it since then, and since I'm the son I can reside there. As I walked in, I reckon I had the same reaction as you did. I was really taken back by the living standard and the change from London. But after a while I eased into it, using the day to travel to Shanghai, I would apply for jobs. I didn't have luck there either, I was getting more frustrated, and I felt the days slip from me again. I started to take more breaks between going to Shanghai, and work on fixing the place, and tend to my garden at the back. Over time, sustaining myself, I realised I didn't have to work again. I can live off my severance, that gains in perpetuity and live off that. But, even if I didn't have that money, I would still be here. I realised how much I let my life get away from me, and I'm now gaining it back. Being in London, I would take trips to Europe and enjoy the time there as a holiday, and splurge for a few weeks. But, I never felt like I let myself heal or get anything from these trips. Only coming here, and letting my body recover, I felt right in the world. I had to change every part of me to do so. For so long I was going by my English name, when I was born I was given the name Jack with no Chinese name. So I took my father's, and I will live the life with what I care about in the center."

He takes a pause, bowing his head to reflect and collect his thoughts.

“When you finish work, do you still see the numbers? Do you see them displayed in your mind? I guess you can see it in the things we build as men, but can you see it in the nature that surrounds you? It doesn’t present itself in the trees, the animals and the sun. Yet we wield it, and destroy something that doesn’t even know the existence of trading, another pawn to make a few more dollars. A finite resource that will be dropped for its every last cent before it can know what is happening, and it deviates what is left. Ocean levels are rising, animals are going extinct, the planet is hotter, just to line our pockets. Thinking about it, I got more repulsed, I even got sick thinking about it. I was getting sick over something that we made up, and I needed to free my mind and find something real. Real as the dirt that seeps in my sandals, as real as the doves that call to each other. In this house I’m sheltered from what our work was before, I look around and can’t see anything that remotely relates to trading. I have come to the realization that most things shouldn’t be exploited, and I have found happiness in living without the pursuit of wealth. ‘

Once he finally stopped, I slouched a bit on my stool, sitting and processing what I just heard. Jack has in his head that he has found that morally he is better because he left the life that he had before for a shack in the woods. He went totally mad, thinking the world needs to give up our wealth. Sing ‘kumbaya’ and hold hands through life, and live only within

our means and nothing more. I felt a pang of discomfort, I was even riled up. Someone who has made their path, and now can reap the rewards. Living in a shack in rural China, not working, I know he is sitting on millions of dollars, and when things get too hard, or he is done with enlightenment he will just go back.

I became blunt after that, I wanted to make sure that I was not following what he was saying. I didn't respond with anything, and he asked for a response. I said I had to go, Jack wanted me to stay longer at least have lunch with him. I said I needed to catch another flight, and lost track of time. I stood up, leaving him sitting on his dumb stool that was too close to the ground. In his fraudulently hut, and in silence to show how his words are nothing but a farce. I wish I could say more to him, tell him he is wrong, but I want to show him. With the money I make, I will buy his hut, and the land surrounding it, bulldoze it and create a resort to make more money, right where he squats on that stool. I simply shook his hand and said "Jack", as a sign of goodbye, he didn't say anything. I turned and walked straight out of his hut, and back the same way to get to the train station bound for Shanghai.

I spent the train ride in silence, mainly because I had no one to talk to, but the anger and betrayal paralysed my thoughts. I only had one thing on my mind, to show up and prove Jack wrong. We now live in a world where money shows the kind

man you are, and if you don't have that to prove anything, you become like Jack and make excuses to why you are not there.

I had no time to lose, so I rushed to the airport. Escorted by staff to first class, I boarded my flight to Saudi Arabia to meet my Son and Wife and have a meeting with the largest weapons manufacturer in the Middle East. Taking half a Xanax that I was Keep Stashed in my suit breast pocket, It was the only Time I had to consider, and eventually use. Dusting off the pocket dust, I shot it down with a swig of Airplane whiskey, and woke up in Saudi Arabia. Met by a chauffeur at the arrivals gate, there were more security guards than usual, even the driver looked like he had a bullet proof vest under his suit. Although I tried to keep calm, from this point on, I started to become more hyper aware of my surroundings.

After blankly handing my baggage to the driver, dismissing his attempts to try to ask how my flight was. I trailed behind him as he was wheeling my luggage and speaking Arabic in his ear piece. I try to adjust to the blast of heat, and try to focus my thoughts as the Xanax wears off. I wait as he opens the automatic door to the 7 seater Mercedes transport van, and hoists myself in using the handle attached inside of the car. I go to the middle row and sit down, not long after he puts my luggage in the back and hops in the front seat. Almost out of breath, he confirms the hotel I'm going to, I

give a weak yes and start to look outside the window as he navigates outside the airport. Rolling down the long stretches of highway, I'm still amazed by the creation of this place. High rises in the middle of the desert, anything you ever need is here, so why don't more people move here?

I'm not too sure when I fell asleep but I woke up in the hotel velvet drop off, and stumbled out of the van. Getting blasted by hot oven heat, I loosen the tie on my suit and walk into the lobby as the bell boy takes my luggage. I explain sharply to the woman at the front desk about my stay, and she quickly hurries for my key to the room. I struggle to walk to the elevator and find my room. But, I do it. I limply swipe my card and almost fall into the room to crash, until I see my wife. She is getting changed for what I presume is dinner with our son. She is surprised to see me, maybe she lost track of time, and forgot when I was going to arrive. I stand in the doorway, as she glides to kiss me while putting an earring in.I kiss her too, and try to hold her waist but she sambas right out of my grip. She explains that she has dinner with our boy soon, but still asks how my stay in China was.

My immediate instinct was just to say, 'It was fine'. But I can't get the interaction with Jack out of my brain. I started to explain about my trip to China, and she was gliding around the room with her loose fighting white linen dress that hugged her chest, and was flowy down the bottom, and gently applying lotion on her tanned skin in a circular

motion. I was mesmerized by her, entranced by her routine. But, my mouth was still producing words about my trip, I knew she didn't want to hear what I had to say, if anything I was sullying the moment of being in her presence. I was even thinking about being with her and my son for dinner, and we are all laughing and talking about nothing serious. But, I couldn't stop. I kept on rambling, getting more stern, vocal. She didn't break out of her movement, but after a while she made a hard stop and looked at me. I couldn't really explain the look, it was a look of annoyance. Like I've disturbed her. She finally says something. It was mainly to reassure me of my standing, she creeps up to me. Although I'm looking down at her because of my height, she stares directly at me and it makes me weak in my knees. Almost terrified by her proximity to me, it's the closest we have been in months and it wasn't a familiar standing. She grabs a hold of the lapel on my suit, a slight tug brings me forward, she has me now. Gently she states,

"You don't know the severity of your drive. You will trade the world away, and believe that you are making a difference in your wealth and security. But you are losing everything, you just can't see it. You are searching for that instant gain, you don't know the carnage you are leaving behind. You suck the life out of everything you touch, like milking a cow from its utters until it's dried up, and you keep all the milk for yourself. You have robbed me for what it's like to truly have purpose in this world. I only care about the things I

buy, and the money I hold. The money you provide me, I'm forever tied to you and I want to blame you , but I blame myself for staying. I can't imagine a life where I would have to work, or not indulge in the excessive wealth you have given me. I hate you for making me get used to it. So I don't care how you feel, I know you, I know your mind is made. You can't... you won't change. What ever happened with you and Jack, is something that should've made you wake up to what you are doing. But, you see it as a threat, a hindrance to whatever you are trying to achieve. You will only listen to yourself."

And as she finished her last word, her facial expression changed. It was like she slipped back out of her conscious state, and with her docile eyes and a faint twitch of her mouth she smiled at me. Straightens how my lapel with her fingers, like her original purpose was to tug and fix it in the first place. She keeps one hand gently on me, and starts to step away. Her finger tips holding on until she has stepped out of reach.

I was left there shocked, I didn't know what to think of what just happened. My heart started to beat really fast as I stood there doing nothing. I could hear it in my temples, and in the rasp of my breath I inhaled. Grabbing her purse off the table in the hallway, she paused and turned around asking if I was coming to dinner. I could only muster saying that I was tired and will sleep instead. She shrugged, turned and left. As the

door was closing, I saw my son standing outside our room. She immediately grew with life as she saw him, and greeted him with a shoulder squeeze, and as they walked away in a smile and laughter. I stand here, out of place. My knees pressing in together but not touching and I'm hunched over a little. I stand in my daze for a couple more minutes, until I have the will power to go to bed. I lay on the bed with my feet dangling, I kicked at the heels to get my shoes off. As I exude the last bit of energy that I needed, and I rest my head on the bed. I can feel my body get heavy, my spine reset, the blood that was pounding in my head seep back into the rest of my body. And I fall into a dreamless sleep.

I woke up to the sun, I woke up in the same position I fell asleep in. I lift myself in a heavy sweep, and look around. My ears slightly ring, and my head is in a fog. I try to tell myself the things I see in my room, my bag, the couch, the TV... and my wife. I move my body to look at her, I could cry at her peacefulness. Her slumber, a place without me in it. She is protected by herself, although her body is with me, I know she is happier in her mind that is away from mine. I turn away, and back off the bed, trying not to disturb her. I walk to the bathroom, and lock the door behind me. I strip down to my socks, I don't bother to hang my suit, and as I turn on the shower to wait for my perfect temperature. I'm paralysed by nothing. There is no thought in my head,I just stand staring at the shower floor until my eyes sting and I blink, walking into the shower immediately after the fact.

Startled by my feet feeling wet merino wool, I quickly come to my senses and take off my socks and go back in. Stepping out of the shower, I put everything back from the floor on. Shave my face, put on an aftershave and brush my hair. Then walk out the door with my brief case. I don't turn back to my wife, I know she is there, I know how she is sleeping.

I met with a weapon's manufacturer in the hotel lobby, and it turns out that they owned the Hotel. We exchanged handshakes, and I assumed we would move to a more formal setting. They asked for my proposal there and then, I gave them the rough guidelines of helping to list their weapon's company as public, and helping create artificial growth through shell accounts until governments and other companies start purchasing stock or even products. It didn't take much convincing, they already had the idea of trading their weapons publically just needed a broker to do it. They did question my past few years as a trader, and my track record. I explained to them it was merely a learning mistake and the conclusion makes for a better investment in the future. We shook hands again, and they asked if I can start with the project later today, without a beat I said yes. Afterwards, they explained that I would be stationed in Saudi Arabia for the foreseeable future, staying in the hotel room I'm in permanently. Trying to collect my thoughts about this decision,I knew it was for the best. I had no life in London anymore, it was a shithole, but a tolerable one, now it's full of bums and radicals. Although it's a sight that

makes me upset, it's something I need to grapple with. At the time of my reflection, they also added that I would be working in the hotel's offices and there would be a space just for me. I asked where it was, and they ushered me to the office. During this time they explained in more detail their goals and vision for this project. I haphazardly listened as I already knew what I'm going to do. As we got to the office, I took it all in. An eight by eight meter room, ultramodern with a view of the city. It was like I was at my old job again, and it made me feel secure for a moment, contrasting from the almost 48 hours of confusion and anxiety. I sit down on the leather office chair, padded like an emes and rest my head all the way back. One of the Spokesman laughed and said I'm settling in well. I nodded and smiled as a response. With a reply of a smile from the man, he pointed to the laptop on the desk and stated that it has all been set up, and the username and password is on a sticky note in the laptop. I look at him and say thank you. They advised that they will leave me to work, and I bid them a goodbye and opened my laptop. As soon as they left, I could hear ringing in my ear. I didn't notice the blood bumping in my ears for that whole interaction, I moved my hands to feel them. They were hot to the touch, and I felt the headache seep through as I became aware of the adrenaline going through my body. I ignored it by starting my work.

I set up a board meeting with people in the company, all guns blazing like I've been there for years. They already had

drafts for fillings to certain stock exchanges, and had concepts of valuations from Banks and other investment institutes. Most of the hard work was already done for me, all I needed to do was pull it all together and create the day of the IPO a success.

The days following the IPO, tensions were brewing, it was great for my returns. Pure green lines sky rocketed on my laptop, and I will ride and edge this high to cash out at the perfect time. Ever since World War 2, these tensions never amounted to anything. It was just hearsay, showing off artillery until the other backs down, or some bullshit peace deal is signed and we are back at square one, but I'm just a little bit richer. But, this time was different. I felt off, more protests, more resistance and apprehension was growing. I had calls blowing up my phone from the spokesmen of the company I listed. I assured them that this is natural, as people are focusing on the actions rather than the companies supplying the arms, a few will de-invest and sell their portion of stocks, but the majority will stay. I appeased them for a bit by having something new to say every time they rang. But, as I look at the news everyday, I knew this wasn't going away. World Wide protests, pressure is rising, resistance groups are gaining traction and influencing their countries to put peace first. I had to stop it. Through the articles I realised there was a name that came up the most, a resistance group based in London that has spread their rhetoric around the world. Finding the leader of the

movement, I see on their Instagram Story that they are still in London. Without thinking about it fully, I book the next flight to Heathrow, running quickly to the hotel room to get my passport. I didn't book a return flight, I would stay until they disband, and until I see change in how the stock is performing. My wife was laying on the bed, she looked like she was in some sort of daze. I see a blister pack on the side of the bed, I assume it's the tranquilizers she takes recreationally. Not to disturb her too much, I just said I'm heading out for a bit, and she just merely let out a noise along with a slight nod. I ran down to the lobby and asked for them to call me for a transfer to the airport, as I needed to leave now to get my flight. I was absolutely wired for the time getting to the airport, going through security and boarding. I managed to sneak half a xanax in my suit pocket, as I always do. I take it as soon as I sit down, and I wake up on the tarmac at Heathrow. My bones are heavy, and my mouth is dry as anything. Breathing hurts, and in a quiet voice I ask the flight attendant to get me a bottle of water, she squeezes past the people who are exiting the aircraft to get one, and make the same way back. I thank her, open the bottle and gulp the whole thing in one go. She looks at me in bewilderment, as she stations herself in a row that everyone has left in, after the gulp I bow my head and rub my brow. But was interrupted by her saying I need to disembark the aircraft. I'm up again, walking straight off, I beeline through the airport, showing my passport at border control and leaving the arrivals section and catching a taxi. I turn on my

phone, and check Instagram, and see that a rally is being held in Traflegar square in the afternoon. I asked the taxi driver to drop me off there. As I look back on my phone, I turn to the camera app, and see my face. I couldn't even recognise myself, sleep has built up in the corner of my eyes, my chin has stubble and I have bags sitting heavy and dark. I scoffed at myself, there was nothing much I could do. I turn off my phone and look outside. London is darker, well darker than usual. More places are shut down, abandoned, people that are on the streets are homeless, drug addicts or just plain undesireable. I almost couldn't believe what I'm seeing. Poverty has struck this city and everyone has fallen. The Taxi driver drops me off at 10:30, I have some time to kill before people start congregating. I run into a Pret a manger, and head straight for their bathroom. I wash my face, with cool water, and shiver initially, but hook my fingers in the corners of my eyes and scrape off the sleep, and pull my hands all the way down to wash off the layer of grease and grim that taints my face. I stare at myself, I don't think of anything, but I'm just in shock at how I look. I grabbed the paper towels next to me, wiped off my face and walked out of the bathroom. I picked up a ready made sandwich, and a bottle of water. And eat at the window, keeping an eye for protesters. I see them rolling in droves over time, and the afternoon crept up. I leave the Pret, and walk towards the crowd. I shuffle my way through the hoards of people, I feel suffocated by them all, but I keep on going forward. I'm almost at the front, and I see people

standing on the podium of King Charle's equestrian statue. I'm in shock at how they got up there, but I knew I needed to get there. I push and squeeze myself far enough to be almost at the base of the statue. I yell out to grab the attention of the speaker, but she's using a megaphone and I'm utterly drowned by it. I keep on yelling and there is no use. I wait for a break in her speech, then I belt a yelp from the bottom of my diaphragm, and my whole chest expands. It was a noise that lasted until it contracted back to its natural position. Her eyes grow wide from what she just heard, and looks down. I catch her eyes, and say we need to talk. She responds with apprehension

"Who are you?"

I didn't really know what to say, well what to say so she didn't turn away.

"I'm going to save you" I reply.

I'm not too sure why this worked, but she kneels down on the statue, and says go around and climb the ladder to come up here. Answering the question how they got up there, I shimmy around the people to get around to the ladder. There are 2 people guarding it, masked teens, they look like they are Uni students, I say that I'm supposed to go up. They stopped me by putting out their arms to block me. I explained again, getting more angry with them me up, they

didn’t budge. It’s hard to admit, but the level of desperation I was facing was so intense, I could feel my hand ball into a fist, and had the urge to punch them in the face, as we stood face to face. Being interrupted by the woman from the top, she yelled out, a voice higher than the rally of people from the crowd to let me up. They step aside, and I grab onto the ladder, having my feet on the first level. I asked the two boys to hold the ladder, and they simply just turned away and faced the crowd. I start to crawl up the ladder, and I feel it wobble underneath me. My breathing pattern did the same, until I reached the top. As I bring my leg over on the stone, the ladder moves away. I panic and freeze, and feel myself go back. Until I stopped as the woman grabbed it before it was too late. I looked up and thanked her, and threw myself off the ladder onto the platform on my stomach. I stand up, dust myself off, and introduce myself. A small woman stands in front of me. I’m not a tall man but I’m looking down at her. She took my handshake and said her name was Mia. She had a tinge of caution in her voice and asked why I’m here and why they need saving. I started to speak, but it was drowned out by the people. I looked up, turned to pan to see how much of the square was filled up. My mind couldn’t comprehend it, swarms of people, it almost looked like there were millions of them. I spotted the Pret I was eating at, and saw that people were up to there, and further, packed like sardines. Posters, flags and flares fill above their heads. To think that the streets were practically empty just a couple of hours before. I could be looking for hours, until Mia tugs at

my sleeve and asks her questions again. I said it's hard to talk over these people, and she suggested we sit down close together so we can hear each other. We find a place at the front legs of the horse, Mia sits conformably under the belly of the horse, but I have to slouch down a bit, bringing my face closer to hers. We are almost sharing the same breath, touching noses even. I flat out and said,

"You need to stop this now"

"Stop what" she replied bluntly, she knew what I meant but wanted to hear it from me.

"The rallies, the protests you need to dissolve your group. It's making the world unstable and the economy is paying the price."

She scoffs and rolls her eyes, it really shows her age.

"Don't you see? The people didn't need this movement, they have been angry for a while. They are restless, and hungry. Look at them." She explained, and allowed me to look up.

I look up again, I know what the crowd looked like. But, seeing it again, I could almost see them vibrate, ready to explode, their anger and frustration visualised.

"People just don't wake up and choose to do this, they are

forced by the burden of their suffering. It gnaws at them until they have no choice but to do something, for the longest time we got nowhere with these protests. But, now we are. Governments are listening, companies are falling, money is being distributed. We can finally see home hope for change, where people can live their lives with relief." She continues while I'm looking.

I looked down back at her, and said "It just needs to stop. Money that supports us will no longer exist, I'm tied up so deeply in the fact that I need you to see it through. I spent my whole life on the pursuit of wealth, that there is no way through but to keep on going. I need this to work, so I can free myself from the financial burdens and make my family happy."

She doesn't do anything for a moment, but gives a gentle smile. I look at her eyes, they are saying a million things, they are light brown, and the sun that creeps through London's overcast skies is hitting them. Her hair is dirty, and messy from the wind, but sits in a short blunt bob.

"Ok, I will stop it."

I really expected to say more to convince her. I pull back in my neck, like I've been lightly slapped.

"Although you didn't introduce yourself fully, I know who

you are. I know what you are trying to do, you want to get rid of all hindering Market factors to make your business venture more profitable. We will stop, and you will make your money. But, I want to warn you, I cannot stop the whole thing. I'm not the creator of this change, just a voice. I'm no different to the people who gathered around us. You can see it in their eyes, hear it in their voices, they are tired of being sucked for every last penny they have, directly or indirectly. I admire you for coming up here, I haven't had someone do that. But, it tells me that you are too far gone in your belief, I knew not to put up a fight because I cannot change you. I will let you go, and I will disperse this crowd. I hope nothing comes from my actions. If so, you will live with them for the rest of your life." She added in a long wind.

I bow my head in relief, I thank her. Grabbing both of her hands to shake them. She stands up, her hands leave mine, and turns around to the crowd. In the megaphone, she explains that the crowd must disperse now. It was immediately met with confusion and audible gasps. I expected it to be mayhem, or push back on her words. To my surprise, they started to leave as she continued to talk, and explain that she will 'bisband' the movement. She drops the megaphone, and leaves by climbing down the ladder. Before I could go over the edge to see her, she disappeared in a crowd that was scattering. No one was supporting the ladder now, so I wobble back down until I'm at the bottom. Most of

the people in a 50 meter radius of me were walking away. Everyone had their backs turned and were walking away to wherever they came from.

I grab my phone from my inside pocket, and give it a ring. I assured the spokesman that the company's growth in the market will now be steady with no bumps, and I will be in the office soon. Making my way back to Heathrow, I tried to take the tube to get to the airport train. But was met with closed gates, and a sign saying there is a strike. Judging by the discoloration of the sign it has been there for a while. I walked back the opposite way to get to regent's park and hail a cab. There was only so much distance that I could cover before hitting a plywood fence about 2 meters high fencing off the houses surrounding regents park. Interested by the sight, I tried not to pay too much attention as I needed to go back home.

I knew betting against peace would make me richer in the long run. What is a peaceful world, without the money you can sustain yourself without work? I knew this was my way out, I would set off a time bomb after I reached my goal on dividend ends. And make the company collapse, I felt like it was a promise I made with Mia by shaking her hands. I want these people to see that it doesn't have to go too far when it comes to making money, if you just have the opportunity to make money you won't have to be in the streets marching and protesting. Setting out to do that, and being back in

Saudi Arabia for the past couple of weeks, I have nearly reached my point of exit. These tensions between nations have boosted the growth of the company to levels I haven't seen before, and I'm about to cash out. Having nuclear scares as well are really helping as well, every country that owns them is showing them off, doing pararades, press conferences and documenting their artillery. I couldn't contain myself at my desk, I've been glued to the desk at my office in Saudi Arabia for a few weeks since I got back. Only going up to my hotel room to sleep, I was utterly fixated on this maneuver, I can finally rest knowing I've corrected my path and I've made my money back from all this time. Having my elbows on the desk, with my hands interlocked resting on my mouth, I look up to see one of the Spokesman at my door. I'm not too sure how long he has been there, but I apologise for not seeing him sooner. He says it's no worry, and I can see that he is spaced out a bit, it must've been a long day for him as it's around 4pm. I asked if there is anything I can do for him, he assures me that everything is up to date and is well. Pausing to say he wants to take me somewhere, I got up without hesitation as I was pretty much done for the day, and I was just looking at the green of the stock line getting greener. I started to walk to him, and he started to walk down the hall. I kept a few steps behind him while walking, and he starts to talk but doesn't look at me.

"We thank you so much for your hard work at our company."

I start to panic a bit, “I’m not getting the can am I?”

“The can?” he replies.

“I’m not getting fired?” I clarified.

“Oh, no no no. I’m just showing one of our facilities in this building just in case we ever need to use it.” he closed.

I’m now intrigued, and he can sense it, like he has eyes on the back of his head.

“With the arms race in full swing, he can expect some sort of escalated conflict. How far people will take it, I’m not too sure. But we made a bunker under the hotel to survive a nuclear attack and sustain a few people for a couple of months.” He abruptly stated.

It did catch me off guard, but I was still listening.

“Why are you showing me now?” I asked.

“We feel like something is coming up, and we want to show you how to enter whenever the time calls for it.” He answered.

“Can I bring my family?” I said in the same beat.

“Of course, we have enough supplies for quite a lot of people, we just say a few people to stop others thinking they can bring as many as they want.” He chuckled.

We took the lift down to the lobby, and walked behind the concierge desk, throwing a door to another hallway. Down that hallway I could see there are more stairs that are now a metal warehouse aesthetic. I start to panic.

“Can I please get my family” I stop in my brisk stride, to talk to him.

“It will only take a minute. After I show you, you can take your family and show them whenever you want.” trying to soothe me.

I hesitate for a bit, but then continue following him. His pace has changed, and as I look back the hallway looks like it’s getting narrower as I look back on the door and it’s practically gone. He marches down the stairs at an increased pace, and I do too. They continue for a couple of flights, and my breath gets heavier, as we travel further underground. He reaches the bottom, and in about 100 meters, I see a big metal door. It had the classic wheel to unlock it, like in a submarine. And as we approached it, he turned the wheel, it took a bit of effort, but as the first shift in the wheel was made, it started to spin with a soft push down, until all the

metal rods holding it in place retracted. He pushes the door open and I see a hallway which I think are hazmat suits. They are way more intense looking than I expected, and the material seems to be a really thick rubber, so I walk closer to them and touch them. It is like thick rubber.

“Cool right, like the movies” He interrupts.

I chuckle and glance at him, “Yeah cool” I use all my might to reply.

My breath gets heavier, there isn’t much air flow in down here, and it’s more humid than usual.

“Please focus on your breathing, you’ll get used to it. Just take a few deep breaths at a time until you get the hang of it.” He directs me, after putting a hand on my shoulder.

After his hand drops, he walks to the next door, it’s the same opening system as the first one. After opening it, there were 4 other men in the room, they were conversing until we walked in and they stopped to look at us. I only recognised 2, the others I haven’t seen before.

“Why are they here? Are they also being shown the bunker?” I immediately questioned.

“Yes, they all just came earlier to get used to being here” He

replies with a smile, and then glances at the men. They all nod and affirm what he was saying.

I grew weary, my heart didn't let up no matter how controlled my breathing was. I started to look around and my surroundings started to get warped. I sat down, and everyone surrounded me and asked if I was alright.

"I need to get my family" I quickly said through my breaths.

"Just have a moment, collect your breaths and thoughts, I think you are having a panic attack." One of the men exclaimed. He had a British accent, and I looked up to see him, he tried to smile earnestly and I knew something was wrong. Then I saw the door behind the men close, I asked why the door was closing.

The Spokesman who led me down the bunker, squatted before me and looked down for a moment. As he raised his head, he started

"We are expecting a nuclear attack to happen in the next 10 minutes."

My heart sank, my whole body had its life snatched from it for a few seconds, and it only returned when I opened my mouth.

“Please I need to go back to them, I need to get my Wife and my boy.” I shout.

“We tried to fetch them from their hotel rooms, and they weren’t there” He informs me regretfully.

“It can’t be right”, then I pause “Why aren’t any one else’s family members here?” I cry.

“Mate, we didn’t want them here. We knew that the world after the fact would not be for them, at least their death would be quick after the fact.” The British man chimes in.

I look at him with a stare that could melt him right there and then. He steps back in silence.

“Please, we can go get them,” I plead. “I have their location,” I added. I pull out my phone, and look at the location app, and shove my phone in everyone’s face. I cried out “Their last known movements 6 minutes ago is in a mall that is 7 minutes away from us”.

“There is nothing we can do, I’m sorry. We are expecting the first missile to fire off in the next few minutes and we have to assess if others would fire.” The spokesman says in a defeated voice. I dropped my head, I knew there was no way I could get my family and come back in time. I sit in silence, all other noise around me means nothing, I feel the blood

rush to my head and it rings throughout my skull, to drain everything else out. Only when I heard an alert in the bunker rang out a few times until it stopped. All the men in the room look at each other, meeting each other in their glances. A collective sigh followed the noise from the speakers.

“I was preparing for it for a while, but I didn’t expect it to happen” One of the men said, without any response from the rest.

To break the silence, a machine started to make a fax-like noise. I looked to see where it was coming from, and paper was flowing from a printer that looked modern but had almost ancient technology. The spokesman informs.

“After dealing with the military, they generously gave us this machine to let us know about missile activity throughout the world.”

One of the men runs to the machine and picks up the end of the sheet.

“Isreal fires at Iran 0745 GMT-6 Time” he says with a shaky breath.

“Does it give any information on what the missile was?” Asks another man, I look at whoever is speaking. My whole body is on autopilot, no one is here.

Suddenly the machine picks up again and prints more. The speed was significantly faster.

“China fires at America, 0747 GMT-6” He adds, “Wait, America fires back at 0748 GMT-6. Russia fires at America 0748 GMT-6”. He keeps on rambling.

“Why are they sending them off so fast?” Someone exclaims, I only saw who they were until they dropped to their knees, burying their head and putting their hands on their ears. No one knows what to do to help him. We are all pretty much paralysed for what seemed like minutes, but felt like hours. The machine kept on printing activity picked up by military bases, until someone shouted to turn it off, the deafening unfamiliar sound ringing out after a plug was pulled. Not even a few moments later, the whole bunker shook. A collective grunt was made by everyone, I knew they didn’t want to scream but the fear still came out. The lights dimmed as the explosion hit, and the Spokesman assured us it would hold. We all sat in silence for a few moments. Afterwards, I could hear faint prayers come from the men in the room. I didn’t say anything, I had nothing to say. All I could think about is my son and wife. I lay where I sat on the bench, held myself and closed my eyes. I had a long, deep dreamless sleep. After waking up, I asked how long I’ve been sleeping, as there was no way to tell I was in the bunker. One of the men replied, I think it’s been around 8

hours. I am still up, and feel the pain in my neck from sleeping without a pillow.

“We have beds, we wanted to move you, but we thought it was better you were uninterrupted” One of the men said.

I twist my neck to help alleviate the pain that I feel, and I look around the room. It was a big room, with facilities. A shower, a gym, beds and other recreational activities. Last night it only felt like a cramped hole, as the military printing machine was only a few paces from where we sat. The spokesman emerges from somewhere and comes up to me. He asks how I am, I say I’m alright, knowing that my wife and son are dead. He advises me to have a shower, and change out of my suit. I nod, and stand up to make my way to the bathroom. He turns around while I’m walking and informs me to be to conservative with the water, with a smile. I could choke him right now, to death, but he was out of my reach as I walked to the bathroom. I entered the bathroom, locking the door behind me. It was modeled as the same ones in the hotel. I turned on the water to keep me from having a panic attack as all the memories washed back. I take off my suit, and empty the pockets, I throw away my phone and wallet and everything else that was in there as they served no use now. In the breast pocket I fished for the loose xanax I kept in there, and brushed off the dust and hair and laid them on the sink’s bench. I strip the rest of my clothes off, and hop in the shower. I wasn’t conservative

with the water, I stood under the boiling shower water for about 7 minutes, doing the same motion of running my hands through my hair to wash it. Eventually breaking under the spell, I turn off the water and dry off. I found a towel in a locker placed opposite the shower, an addition that is not in the hotel rooms, but necessary if the 6 of us are living together now. In the locker, a white robe hangs from the top, and it's a garment worn by most people in Saudi Arabia. I pull it over me, and it fits nicely, and I hurry back to my pills on the bench and put them in the breast pocket on the front. I stepped outside the bathroom, and my first step on the bunker's concrete floor sent a shiver down my spine. The hair on my nape sticks up like a cat's, and I'm immediately reminded of where I am. All the men are sitting together at a table, and they motion for me to sit down. I join them reluctantly, and see the meal before me.

"To make the transition to our new bunker life, we have stocked some fresh foods for the next few days. As they will perish soon, it would be shameful for them to go to waste. So I would like it if we all sat down and had a beautiful meal." The Spokesman announces, standing at the head of the table.

I glance at him as he sits down, and then at my food. It was steak, roast potatoes and green beans. Although it's hard to track the time, I knew it was early morning. I guess anything goes now. I cut into the medium rare cut of beef on my plate

and ate it. I knew it was supposed to taste nice, I could see everyone indulge in their portion, hoovering the meat like it's not possibly the last cuts left on earth. I could only put it in my mouth and chew it down, stomaching it was another thing that required most of my focus. So I remained silent at the table, and let everyone converse amongst themselves. After dinner was done, I excused myself from the table. I knew I would have to clean my setting, but I was exempt given my fragile nature, and I returned to a bunk. The bed was a stretcher but a really comfortable one, it gave the whole bunker an army feel, and everytime I see my surroundings I remember what reality is. I have my hands on my body to hold myself for comfort, and as I move my hands on my chest, I feel the xanax lightly create a print on my pocket. They are whole ones, pinching to feel the bar shape with my fingers. I could feel 3, having them will have me in a daze for a week or so, just enough time to move past the initial shock. I take one out of the pocket, and swallow it dry. It went down my throat but I could feel it burn in my chest, almost feeling like it was stuck. I lay back down after having it, and take some dry swallows to try and push it down more. I could feel my body start to change, detach itself. I felt happy for once in the past 24 hours, and slowly descending into a lull, I could hover around this underground man cave for a bit.

I spent most of my day sleeping, or if I wasn't sleeping I was in a comatose state in my stretcher. Most people didn't

bother me, I usually waved them off if they came up to me, but I managed to muster the strength to speak if they tried to press me further. I timed my pill taking very well, after I could feel them start to wear off. I went to have a shower, wash off the come down that usually coincides with meal time, and still have fresh food at this time. And after my meal, I would take another. Although it was a routine that would only last for a couple of days, I was happy in my state. I knew the come down that I couldn't shake would arrive, but I wanted to spend the time I could being indisposed.

Eventually when the last Xanax wore off, I had my ritualistic shower and meal, and after I knew I couldn't return to my stretcher, have a pill and float through the next week. So I stayed sitting at the table. This time, I showered off my hangover, and I could feel my joints announce their presence by screaming in pain, and I felt the swirls of liquid in my head they were gushing and making a deafening noise in my head. I don't know how long I was sitting at the table, until the Spokesman came up to me. He pulled the chair beside me, and inched closer to me as he sat down.

"How are you feeling?" He asks gently, in a soothing voice.

"I don't know", I reply with no thought. I genuinely had no feelings or thoughts going through my mind, it was just the answer my body allowed me to say.

“I know it’s hard, and you know we are all here for you. How about participating in our chores or activities to help ease your mind.” He explains.

I turn my head slowly towards him, and try to pierce my stare straight through him to tear his brain apart. He could sense that I’m offended by his statement.

“Please let us help you, we will be in here for a while until everything cools down outside” He tries to diffuse the tension.

“I need to leave” I counter.

“What?” He says with visual shock in his body.

“i need to leave, right now” I re-iterated.

“There is nothing out there, why would you want to go out there?” He explains, but has genuine curiosity in his voice.

“I need to go right now” I say again, now with my voice raised.

The rest of the men sitting down away from the table, start to turn around. Curious to see what is happening.

“Alright, Alright. Please lower your voice. I don’t want to startle the rest of them.” Trying to diffuse the situation.

He turns to the men, gives them a forced smile and waves them away. As they all return back to whatever they were doing, he faces me again.

“Alright, I will let you out. But, it would have to be when everyone is sleeping” He snaps in an assertive tone.

I nod to confirm the plan, as my body is spent and I have no strength to talk. He raises up from his chair, he looks annoyed by my decision. I knew he didn’t want to convince me to stay as I was not pulling my weight, and pretty much was a liability for everyone and harming the unity of the group. I sit at the dinner table until people start to get ready for bed. I didn’t remove my plate from the table, or brush my teeth. I just took myself to my cot, and lay in the darkness when the lights went off. I drifted in and out of sleep, it’s always hard for your body to adjust to sleeping on its own after relying on sedatives for the past week. Until I felt a strong grip on my shoulder, I must admit it did startle me, as I was violently awakened from my daze. It was the spokesman, he is holding a flash light that is carefully guided by his hand not to shine in my face. He gestures to me to sit up, and as I do, I swing my legs to the side of the cot and stand up. I match his height, and he guides me to the door. He put the flashlight in my hands, and I knew to shine

it on the hatch that opens the door. He places his hands on it, and stands in a firm stance to twist the handle to open the door. In one strong push, it budges and he eases his strength to open it gently, being mindful of the noise that can come from being reckless. As the door opens, I walk into the room before the other door, seeing the protective suits before me.

“Take one,” he whispers.

I nod, and take the closest one near me off the hook and examine it. I look until I see a zip at the back, and unzip from the neck to the lower back. I step in it with my white dressing ground. It feels weird having a dress like garment be moulded to fit into the pants of the suit, b ut I’m far too gone to go back and change. As I pull the hood over me, the Spokesman steps towards the back of me and zips the back. I turn around, and shake the man’s hand. I can feel his skin through the thick rubber glove that is attached to the suit. We hang in the light that is softly illuminating the room, as the torch is placed on the bench that stretches from one side of the room to the other, underneath the hung suits. It was hard to see his face, but his eyes were full, and caught what little light there was. I can see it was a plea, but he knew I was going to leave. I pull back my hand from the shake after the fact and turn around.

A soft whisper floats in the room “Please wait until I’ve fully closed this door before you open the other”.

I turn back and nod at him, as I knew the voice came from him. With this cue, he slowly backs out of the room, and I see the door slowly close behind me until a sharp pull is made to get it shut. I heard the hatch spin to a full stop, I knew I was sealed off, there was no turning back.

I was about to walk to the other door, then I realised the torch, I quickly scurried back for it. Trying to get used to how clunky the suit was. I pick up the torch and head back to the spinning hatch. I placed the torch under my arm pit, as I put both of my hands on the wheel, and gave it a big tug towards the ground to get it spinning. As it's freed, I take the torch from under my arm pit and shine it on the door, using the other hand to keep it spinning until all the prongs that keep it sealed are retracted. As the door opens a bit on its own, I know the door locks are fully retracted and I push with my hand to get it open. I was immediately met with a fog and particles which filled the air. The flashlight only penetrates around 30 centimeters in front of me, so I'm cautious with where I step, until I reach the stairs. I start to climb them, and I can hear my breathing echo in the suit, audibly getting louder. There is only so much this suit can filter, and I knew whatever I'm breathing would eventually kill me. Eventually I reach the top, and push through the way the Spokesman showed me before to the hotel lobby. In my shock I take in what I'm seeing.

The Building is still structurally sound, the foundations are still intact, but everything is blowing to bits. Glass littered the floor, pieces of furniture were torn to shreds. Bodies are scattered around the floor, some intact others having their body smeared on the floors or the walls. Some have melted to the tiles, or the plaster walls. The ones on the walls looked like they had adhered to it, and would need a spatula to scrape them off. What I'm seeing is so horrific but my mind could not comprehend the scene. All I could do was laugh at the absurdity. I coughed out a laugh. My body was holding back out of respect for the dead I saw before me. I battle with it for a bit, until I give up and chuckle to myself for a bit until I come to my senses. I walk around the ground floor of the hotel, more of the same scenes, slowly I can stomach seeing the charred bodies. As the flashlight could illuminate a bit further, I see a fire escape. I had the urge to go back to my room, something called for me to go there. So I took the stairs again, it was about 20 flights to get to my room. Huffing and puffing my way up, I managed to get to the floor, and room I was originally staying in. As I walked to the door, I noticed it was the only one on the floor that was closed. Just as an outlier of my pattern recognition, I was naturally curious. I approach the door handle and slowly turn it to open. As I do, the fog that filled everywhere was more dense, it was hard to see and significantly harder to breathe.

I instinctively say "Hello" outloud as I shine my torch to all

parts of the room. Until I see two slim hands grip the edge of the couch. I felt a shiver go down my spine, that made my whole body tense. As the hands flex, and forearms follow to a body popping out. I step back, bumping into the table behind me as I hand shines the torch on it. I gasp. I see my wife before me, her frame is the same. But the image of her is burned. The skin on her body is now a different charred shade, darker than her tan, all over the texture is different. Parts are peeled off, where it's just the pink of her muscles showing, or it's bubbling with puss or wrinkled. I can faintly see her purple cashmere sweater melted into her skin. Parts of it hide under her skin, but the general silhouette is where her body wore it before. After overcoming the shock, I step towards her. She stays in place, she shudders from the light of my flashlight fixed on her. Get closer to try and embrace her, to celebrate her being alive. She finally lets me get closer, and I feel her press on my rubber suit as I place my hands around her. I can't feel her arms behind me, I don't know if she isn't hugging me or the suit is just too thick. I ask where our son was, and she opens her mouth and nothing comes out. She is surprised, shocked and upset all in the span of a few seconds, she panics for a bit. But before I could calm her down, it seems like she's content with her vocal cords being either obliterated by the blast, or simply clogged from all the shit in the air. She walks towards the bathroom, and I follow her. As we approach the door, she lifts her arm up to push the door open. It's like she's raising a tonne of bricks, but it's just the bone of her arm. Literally

the bone, it was like her skin melted and the muscle washed away, then the skin solidified back on her bone, along with her purple cashmere sweater. As the door slowly opened from the little force given by my wife's push, the bathroom was darker and more foggy than the hotel room. I cough immediately and heave at what I'm smelling and inhaling, I try to suppress my fit to find my son. Until I hear a faint wheeze coming from the bath tub. I approached the bath with slow steps to try lessen the blow of the horror I would see, but no matter how slow I walked. Nothing could prepare me for this. I stand at the edge of the tub and move my body to see the bottom of the bathtub.

There perfectly in the center lies my son. I can see a soft outline of him in a fetal position. His actual body's shape is subdued by the matter that surrounds him. Most of his insides have melted out of him, and pooled at the bottom of the tub. Through the time of the last blast, they have solidified and grew into their own spores. Mounds of flesh are now mutated piles that bubble and breath on their own. Their own veins growing up from the bottom of the bath, almost reaching the top of the tub. My observations were interrupted by the wheezing that came from him. His skull is exposed, and his cheek bones protrude from the mound of flesh that was his body. I look at him in disbelief of how we got here. I look directly into his whole eye, his socket is still attached within the skull, and then I see it quickly glance at me. I try not to jump back, instead I kneel down on the

ground and try to pat his head. Whatever I tried to deem his head was close enough to his eye to still see me. His wheezing grew louder, and I looked down to where his lungs and heart might be, and saw them beat like a rabbit's, at such a speed I knew it would kill him. I pulled back, and the intensity of the breathing went back to normal. I stood up from my kneeling position to turn back to my wife, she's just standing at the door frame, motionless, silent too. I told her to go outside, and nudge her slightly so she could understand what I meant. As she took an unsteady step back, it was enough for me to close the door. As I do, I rest my head on the door, and take a deep breath. I walk to the toilet, and place my gloved hands on the top of the back of the toilet and take off the lid. It was heavy in my hands as I held it, and walked towards the bath tub. I stare at my son one last time, his fate contained in the tub he lays in. I heave the lid above my head, and I see him stare at me and his breathing hastens again, until he looks away to the side of the tub rather than me. I knew he had no eyelids to close his eyes, he wanted to do everything he could not to see this. I stretch my body as much as I can to the ceiling, and with a calculated swoop I bring the lid down, leaving my hands at just the right time where the force will explode his head on impact. And it did, whatever exposed organs were slightly contracting when he was alive now stopped, and so did his wheezing.

I stare at the lifeless body, well what I could see pass the

toilet seat's lid. From the impact of the throw, his body exploded climbing up the walls of the tub, I couldn't look at it any longer. So I turn away and walk back to the living room. As I open the door, I see the face of my wife, her new face. I must admit, it did startle me, from the time I left the bathtub I forgot what events occurred a week ago. She stands there swaying like a weak candle flame, with a blank expression on her face. I don't know if she can change her facial expressions, or she just didn't want to. I don't say anything for a bit, and in time I can hear the faint wind from outside. The air so high up was still so thick, even with all the windows blown out. I break the almost silence by telling her we should get out of here. I step closer to her, taking her hand, trying not to squirm from what I'm feeling even through the thick gloves. I led her to the end of the room, and I could feel her drag behind me, her walking pace was significantly slower than mine. I knew it would take an eternity to walk down the flights of stairs. She was apprehensive about leaving the room, she stood at the door frame, almost paralysed by fear. I used my body to usher her, and show her the way out, reassuring her it's fine. She moves to take my hand, and I gladly secure it in mine, we walk a bit faster until we reach the staircase. I gave a big push to open the fire escape door, and hold it open with my body, leading my wife past me until she was fully in the stairwell. I walk a bit further than her, and take two steps down the stairs and hold my hand up for her to take. She shuffles closer to the stairs, and with great agony she takes

the first step. Her moving her hips down to reach the first stair ignited her to exude a sound that I could only describe as pain. As her voice was lost, I could read what she was mouthing in silence as something of intense pain. I had the flashlight shining on her as a guide, and it was the first time I saw the little muscles that are attached to her skull move and contract in a way that she could show her pain as well. I really felt for her, and I knew it would be a treacherous way down. Slowly, slowly, one step at a time, we inched down the stair case, slower than snail's pace until we reached the end. As she took the last step, she kept her hand on the rail, and lent slightly to take a break, each level we took to come down, her breathing became heavier, until it became like a wheeze like my sons. I couldn't bear to hear it, but as she took the break it returned to a normal breathing pattern. I quickly take a few steps to the door, and hold it open for her. She had gained the confidence to walk by herself, and she stepped out into the lobby before me. Seeing the carnage I saw from the blast, she has to physically move her entire body. I presume her neck muscles have adhered to her spine, or something is keeping it from turning. She wanders off, and I hang back to give her the space to get her footing. She approaches where the entrance used to be, and I come up to the side and tell her we need to go out to survive.

As she always trusts me, she starts to walk towards the door. I walk beside her matching her pace until we are fully outside. Getting hit with an immediate gust of wind, I see